Chapter 0

The Girl Who Played with Magic

"Legends never die. They just wait for someone to turn the volume up."

The world had changed beyond recognition.

Castles had become ruins buried beneath megacities. Ancient kingdoms existed only in history books, their heroes reduced to illustrations and half-forgotten myths. The old magic that had once shaped civilizations had been replaced by machines, artificial intelligence, and energy systems capable of powering entire cities.

Above the streets, automated aircars weaved between skyscrapers. Neon advertisements flickered across buildings that stretched into the clouds, while holographic performers danced above crowded intersections. Beneath the endless glow of artificial light, millions of people lived their lives connected to networks, implants, and machines they barely understood.

Humanity had entered an age where almost everything could be manufactured.

Everything except magic.

Or so everyone believed.

Our story begins with a girl who had absolutely no interest in any of that.

She was seventeen, perpetually sleep-deprived, and had a playlist for practically every situation imaginable. She rode a heavily modified motorcycle through the neon-lit streets, wore oversized headphones even when they weren't playing anything, and considered spending an entire afternoon without music a fate worse than death.

She wasn't a genius hacker, a legendary bounty hunter, or some chosen heroine waiting for destiny to call.

She was just a girl who liked loud music, fast bikes, and minding her own business.

At least, that was what she thought.

One rainy evening, while escaping the crowds of the lower city, she stumbled upon an old bookstore wedged between a closed-down electronics shop and a vending machine that had been out of order for

eleven years.

The place looked as though it had survived several centuries by sheer stubbornness.

Its wooden sign was faded. Its windows were covered in dust. And unlike the buildings surrounding it, the bookstore had no digital display, no security drones, and no connection to the city's commercial network.

Naturally, she went inside.

The owner was an elderly woman who seemed entirely unsurprised by the arrival of a teenager dripping rainwater onto her floor.

After wandering between the shelves, the girl found two books that caught her attention.

The first was titled Paladin, an old account of a warrior who had sworn to protect the innocent in a world divided by fear and prejudice.

The second was called Revolution, a collection of stories about a notorious outlaw who had challenged a corrupt government in an age of steam-powered machines and crystal energy.

Both books were strangely detailed for historical fiction.

Their characters felt real. Their struggles were painfully human. And their descriptions of ancient technology seemed far too specific to be mere inventions.

She borrowed both.

That night, she began reading.

She had no idea that the stories were not entirely fictional.

She had no idea that the warrior and the revolutionary had lived in the same world she now called home.

And she certainly had no idea that her own family history was hidden somewhere between their pages.

Because long before humanity learned to industrialize the power of the Elven stones, there had been others who could wield their energy without machines.

They were among the first humans to receive the stones from the Elves themselves.

They had not stolen them.

They had been entrusted with them.

And for that, they had been hunted.

They were called witches.

Centuries passed. Kingdoms fell. Their names were erased from official records, their descendants scattered, and their abilities dismissed as superstition. Only a handful survived, carrying their secrets through generations of fear and silence.

The girl was one of them.

She simply hadn't found out yet.

Her blood carried an extraordinary ability: she could draw upon the energy of a power stone without losing most of its potential to the limitations of human technology. Where machines required elaborate converters and carefully regulated systems, she could channel the raw energy directly.

And when that power awakened, it responded to something she had carried with her for as long as she could remember.

Music.

Rhythm became a pathway for her magic. Melody shaped its flow. Every beat gave her power a new form, transforming invisible energy into luminous sigils, spectral projectiles, and weapons that seemed to materialize from the sound itself.

Her favorite creation was a pair of magical firearms.

They appeared in flashes of neon light, their sleek, impossible shapes traced in glowing symbols. Their shots followed the rhythm of whatever she was listening to, each burst of energy striking like a beat in a song only she could hear.

She could fight to a melody.

She could dance through a firefight.

And if the music was good enough, she could turn an entire battlefield into her own stage.

But power always attracted attention.

The moment her abilities awakened, dormant systems began detecting an energy signature that had not appeared in centuries. Somewhere in the depths of the city, an organization that had spent generations burying the truth received a signal they had never expected to see again.

A witch had returned.

And this time, she was living in an age where every street had a camera, every network had a watcher, and every secret could become a target.

The girl still had her motorcycle.

She still had her headphones.

She still had two borrowed books sitting beside her bed.

But the next time she put on her favorite song, the world would hear something it had tried to silence for centuries.

Magic.

And the witch who carried it had no intention of turning the volume down.